

The Rubber-Band Guitar

Easy start · Indoors · Grown-up nearby · Ages 5–10 · 20 min

Brought to you by Stacey — “If it makes a sound, it can make a song.”

Stretch four bands over a box and work out why some of them sing higher than others.

WHAT YOU NEED

- An empty tissue box or a shoebox with a hole cut in the lid
- 4 rubber bands of different thicknesses
- 2 pencils
- Tape

BEFORE YOU START

Rubber bands snap. Point the box away from faces while you stretch them on.

A grown-up cuts the hole in the box.

How to make it

- 1 Stretch the four rubber bands around the box, across the hole, spaced apart.
- 2 Slide a pencil underneath the bands at each end so they lift off the box.
- 3 Pluck each band and listen. Put them in order from lowest to highest.
- 4 Look at the ones that sounded highest. What do they have in common?
- 5 Now move one pencil closer to the other and pluck the same band again.
- 6 Work out how to play three different notes on a single band, then play a tune.

TALK ABOUT IT

How is your box like a real guitar, and what is the box itself doing to the sound?

TRY THIS TOO

Fill the box halfway with rice and play it again. What changed?

DID YOU KNOW? · SOUND & RHYTHM

Tighter and thinner strings make higher sounds. A plucked band vibrates back and forth. Thin, tight, short bands vibrate faster, and faster vibrations reach your ear as a higher note. Every stringed instrument is built around this one idea.